dummy figure of a horse on his / her hips. This folk dance needs a lot of training and skill. The dummy is made of lightweight materials and the cloth at the sides of the dummy swings to and fro covering the legs of the dancer who dons wooden legs so that they look like the hooves of the horse. While performing, the dancer brandishes either a sword or a whip.

Parai Aattam is a special type of dance in Tamil culture in which the performers beat the parai and dance to



its rhythm. This is one of the oldest traditional dances. In olden days, the parai was used for multiple reasons, ranging from warning people about the upcoming war, requesting civilians to leave the battlefield, announcing victory or defeat, stopping a breach of a water body, gathering farmers for farming activities, warning wild animals about human presence, during festivals, weddings, celebrations, worship of nature and so on. Parai Aattam plays a prominent part in all the celebrations in Tamil Nadu even today.

Bommalaattam or Puppetry is held in rural areas of Tamil Nadu during festivals and fairs. Skilled puppeteers



manipulate the puppets with strings or wires. They stand behind a screen and the puppets are held in front. The puppetry depicts stories mainly from the Puranas, epics and folklore. Even during Indian freedom struggle awareness programmes for the common people were conducted through puppet shows to instill patriotism among the people.

Therukoothu is usually conducted during village festivals in the months of Aadi and Panguni. Theru koothu is performed on the streets and in open air. In this dance form, make-up and costumes are considered very important. The performance involves storytelling, songs, dance and dialogue



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